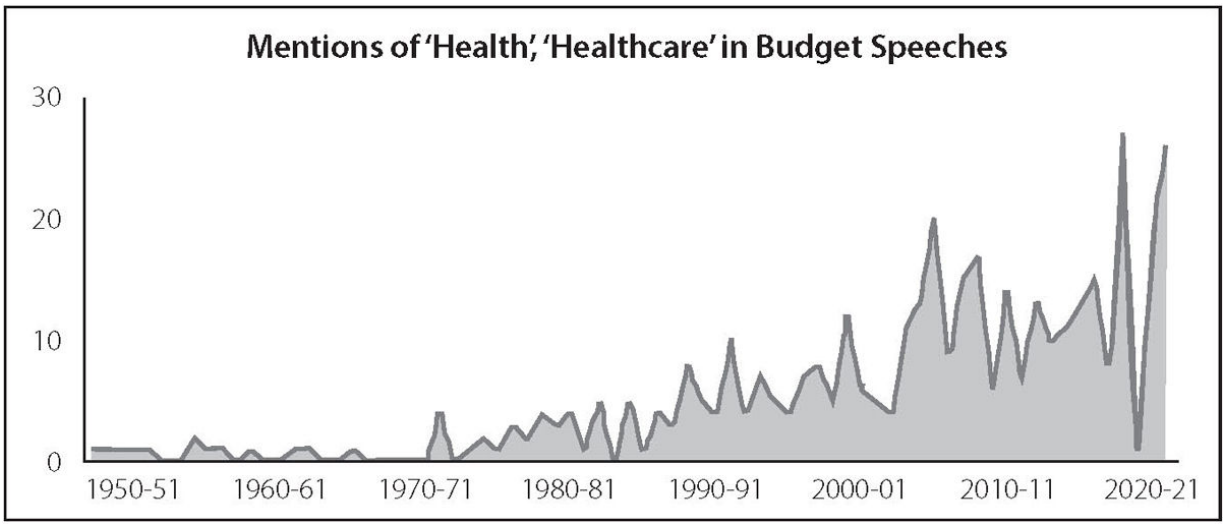
social agenda (see Figures 10.17 and 10.18). One would have thought that health would have figured prominently in budget speeches over the years. In fact, it was only in 1988-89 that finance ministers started mentioning 'health' prominently in their budget speeches. The word was mentioned twenty-seven times in the 2018-19 speech by the then finance minister, Arun Jaitley, while announcing the 'world's largest healthcare programme'. However, it was mentioned just once in the 2019-20 budget before seeing a huge spike in 2020-21 during the pandemic.

Figure 10.17: Modi Government Significantly Upped Talk on Health and Education Towards End of Its First Term, Much More than UPA-2 (Budget Speeches: 1950-51 to 2020-21)



Source: Budget speeches by Union finance ministers. Analysis by Rishabh Srivastava, Nalin Mehta, PollNiti

Figure 10.18: Modi Government Significantly Upped Talk on Education Towards the End of Its First Term, Much More than UPA-2 (Budget Speeches: 1950-51 to 2020-21)